

Chapter Title: Theological Method

Book Title: Paulos Mar Gregorios

Book Subtitle: A Reader

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Published by: Augsburg Fortress, Fortress Press. (2017)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1tm7hk0.31>

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Theological Method

ENGAGING IN PHILOSOPHICAL THEOLOGICAL REFLECTION

The aversion of our contemporary civilisation to metaphysics and deep philosophical reflection is partly understandable in relation to the Western experience where philosophy has often led people astray. Philosophy can be a source of deception and error and it often has been. But without philosophical-theological vision, people are reduced to a pragmatism wherein also people can be manipulated and misled.

I would therefore enter a strong plea to Christians that they should not abandon fundamental philosophical-theological reflection and a constant and active willingness to learn from the traditions of others. I say this with deep gratitude for all I have—be it so imperfectly—learned through the years from so many cultures, European, American, African and Asia. The very diversity of religions and cultures should not be taken in the sense that since no one of them can be exclusively right, therefore all of them must be equally wrong. The trans-conceptual apprehension of reality lies beyond all human religion and beyond all conceptual grasp; but one moves toward a richer trans-conceptual apprehension as one passes through a large variety of conceptual and symbolic apprehensions of reality. Plurality is a witness to the many-dimensional splendour of reality. (SSS 75–76)

THEOLOGICAL LANGUAGE AND SECULAR LANGUAGE

The secular language and conceptual framework as it now exists is a contribution of modern science. It has now become a universal language. We can therefore use it in our universities, in our political assemblies, in our international bodies like the UN and its agencies. It is a great instrument of human communication across the globe.

Human beings can now speak to each other about common problems facing humanity, be they Buddhists from Thailand, Marxists from the Soviet Union, Muslims from Saudi Arabia, Protestants from Denmark, Catholics from Argentina or Agnostics from North America. This is already a great achievement for which one thanks God at every secular world conference.

Do we now have a language in which to appeal to the conscience of humanity on a global scale? We may think that we do, because we have now a global elite educated in modern secular universities. And it is this elite that gathers at world conferences. They do speak a common language. But this common language itself suffers from the limitations of present science. They can speak about resources, skills, personnel, production, distribution, organisation, politics, economics, sociology, culture, psychology, physics, chemistry, biology, and a host of other disciplines and effectively communicate with each other. They can even talk about values like human dignity and freedom, national and international justice, the unity of humanity and so on.

Yet, it is this very secular language that sometimes inhibits people from speaking effectively to each other about the meaning-structures that underlie our value choices. By meaning structures I mean the implied conceptual or symbolic perception of reality and of goals toward which to advance. Here we have so far operated with two sets of secular systems—that of Marxist humanist ideology or of Western liberal humanist ideology. In both of these, the adjective “humanist” points to the fact that the central concern is humanity and its destiny. The nature of this humanity is conceived in both systems as the highest known product of the evolutionary process. The origin of the process itself is attributed in either system as inherent in “nature” or matter-energy in process of evolution. This is an unsatisfactory explanation, since it says that the process is due to the process itself. The process is assumed to be self-existent, autonomous.

Those who see the problem of explaining the origin of the process, resort to philosophical dogmas about the meaninglessness of the question since it cannot be answered by science. Even a reputed scientist like Steven Weinberg, who gives the impression in his *The First Three Minutes* that science can explain the origin of the process, resorts to devious ways of reasoning to cover up the fact that the question of the origin of the process of the universe is at present beyond the reach of science, due to limitations in method and framework of realization. The Marxist on the other hand also starts with a quasi dogmatic assumption: "In the beginning was matter-energy, with the principle of dialectical contradiction contained within it."

Neither can secular scientific thought, whether Western liberal or Marxist dialectical, provide us with much of a clue as to the final destiny of humanity and the universe. Either can fix proximate goals like "a society of happy people" or in the more precise WCC secular language "the just, participatory and sustainable society," or in a Marxist language "a classless communist society." But these are only proximate goals in history, and do not satisfy the deepest aspirations in man, which include some concern about a personal and common destiny beyond history, beyond death. Nor do they deal with the aspirations of those who want to enter a deeper level of the realization of self—as in the Eastern religions of Taoism, Buddhism and Hinduism. And especially because of this failure to respond to the deepest in humanity, our ideological conceptions of proximate corporate destiny in history fail to attract the deepest loyalties—whether it be in Western liberal humanism or in Marxist dialectical humanism.

Failure to deal fundamentally with origin and destiny has direct consequences for the present. Man constantly searches self-understanding and understanding of the good. These are the basic notions, even when conceptually unclear, which determine the value choices of persons and societies. Precisely because of its failure to deal with origin and destiny, not only does secular ethical reflection become superficial in its value choices, it is unable to draw out the deepest loyalty of man in the pursuit of these values.

The secular movements of modern times are directly rooted in the Renaissance and the Enlightenment, and in the enthronement of conscious and conceptual reason as the source of all enlightenment.

Modern science is a child of the Enlightenment or perhaps they are sisters born from a common mother.

But there is no reason why science should be permanently committed to the secular. I believe that the liberation of science from the secular has already begun. I see indicators of this in several current phenomena: (a) the frantic search of young people in industrially advanced societies for fulfillment in Eastern religious realizations like Yoga meditation and even espousal of Hinduism and Buddhism in various new forms (e.g., Krishna consciousness, Zen); (b) the growing attention by scientists to psychic phenomena hitherto ignored by modern science (e.g., physical research, more in socialist countries than in the West; scientific studies on bio-feedback, altered states of consciousness, energy and force fields, meditation research, on dying and the mystical consciousness, etc.); (c) the growing realization of ecological awareness moving toward an acceptance of the cosmic relations of humanity, that is, that man is inextricably linked to the whole of reality and does not exist apart from the various fields that constitute the universe; (d) the growing centrality of the fable, the legend, the fantastic and the mythological in Soviet entertainment—in ballet and opera the most popular ones today are those that have something to do with extra-human entities and forces.

These are all reasons why we should be circumspect about accepting the usual secular ethos of science as somehow indispensable. After all the very clarity of the concept “secular” is today in serious doubt. Usually, it refers to a particular phenomenon of Western history. After a period of domination of all thoughts, symbols, ideas and institutions by the dogmatism and clerical imperialism of the Western Church, these thoughts, symbols, ideas and institutions developed sufficient momentum to break loose from the clerical yoke and sought to establish themselves on autonomous foundations. The very enthronement of conceptual reason was due to the need to fight against the confining yoke of the authority of dogma and tradition. The separation not only between Church and state, but also between Church and socio-cultural institutions like those related to education and medicine as well as art and music, was a direct consequence of the revolt against ecclesiastical domination. The very notion of “secular” in the modern sense was born in that revolt.

It has been a very fruitful revolt and has spawned many ideas and institutions which have now become the common property of many

people everywhere (hospitals, schools, forms of democratic government). They, probably, would not have been so universally accepted had they been inseparably attached to the Christian Church and clerical domination.

But does this mean that humanity has to remain forever under the new yoke—the yoke of the secular? After all, the secular is a concept very hard to define or defend philosophically. In essence it meant belonging to the *saeculum*, or time-space world and not to the Church, which was supposed to be concerned with the open world—that of *eternitas*. Later it was given the definition of time-relatedness that is changing with the times, or constantly readjusting to temporal change. Still later it was given the meaning that it deals with reality in terms of this world and no other, which meaning was used for an attempt by theologians to interpret the meaning of even the Christian faith in purely this-world terms (Bishop Robinson's *Honest to God*, Paul van Buren's *The Secular Meaning of the Gospel*, Harvey Cox's *The Secular City*, Ted van Leeuwen's *Christianity in World History*, and the whole *death of God* movement in theology, as well as many liberation theologies).

The secular movement is today to be criticised for precisely its unscientific assumptions, namely, that this world can be understood in its own terms without reference to a beginning or source which remains inexplicable in science. The Christian Church having once controlled science, need not so kow-tow to science as to be afraid to question its unwarranted imposition of the secular frame on human consciousness. The Church must have confidence enough in its own thought-frame, which believes that this universe is not self-existent but created, that this universe is not autonomous but contingent, that this universe has a destiny that is set by God but in the shaping of which human beings are privileged to participate. It is at these points that the Church refuses to be intimidated by the secular tempo of science.

And yet, the secular language remains the only common language in which the peoples of the world can converse with each other and come to common understanding and purposes.

What shall the religious traditions then do? For some traditions like Buddhism and Taoism which are not conceptually theistic there seems to be no difficulty in adopting secular language. This however, is an illusion. For all these religions are heavily dependent

on tradition, and cannot establish themselves by pure conceptual reason, though many apologists have unsuccessfully attempted such defense in the past.

Tradition thus becomes a key concept in theological or religious ethics in dialogue with secular ethics. Today science itself begins to recognise the role of community and tradition in the maintenance and development of science. True, most of the formulations and theories of science are available in written form; but no scientist acquires all of his skill and knowledge from written books or articles; neither medicine nor surgery as scientific skill and knowledge can be wholly acquired from books. Nor do even the more abstract sciences like mathematics or astronomy become actually transmitted through books alone. There is a constant interaction between teacher and student, between scientist and scientist through which science becomes transmitted and developed in the scientific community. Tradition, of course, generally includes written as well as unwritten elements.

There is a mistaken assumption among some theologians that ethics can be directly derived from the scriptures; or from the scriptures plus rational reflection. But when we analyse the process of ethical reflection we find that the ethicist also uses various exegetical traditions in choosing particular passages and in interpreting them. He may cite chapter and verse plus the authority of particular professors. . . . It was clear to many of us that Liedke was himself heavily dependent on a particular geographical and confessional tradition in doing his exegesis. It seems an illusion that one can move from scripture to ethics without going through tradition.

But the fact remains that one has still to resort to secular language if one is to carry conviction to those outside the particular religious tradition from which the ethicist speaks. This gives rise to what I call "the principle of two languages" in ethical reflection on common social issues. One may arrive at a particular ethical choice starting from tradition which includes scripture and its interpretation. Quite often, especially for the Eastern Orthodox theologian but not only for him, tradition is carried in symbols like the Eucharist, the meaning of which can never be exhaustively conceptualised. The language of tradition thus involves trans-conceptual experience, and can never be fully translated into secular language. It includes myths, images, and symbols. This is true also in science which is heavily dependent on

paradigms and images—for instance, waves, particles, fields, systems, spin, flow and so on.

The task of the Christian theologian is then to have two sets of languages—one, that of religious tradition, which he uses for discussion among his fellow religionists and others interested, and another secular language which he uses for conversations with those who accept only the secular mode of reasoning. But the first cannot be exhaustively translated into the second. And quite often when new questions arise in the second, the theologian has to go back to the first in order to derive inspiration and guidance.

Even more significant is the fact that neither of them is static. The theological tradition when it refuses to learn from the new insights of science and secular thought becomes stale and irrelevant. A constant interaction between the two languages and the two modes of awareness seems essential for the validity of both traditions. Science too needs to develop the two-language system, especially as each discipline becomes increasingly more complex, technical and incomprehensible to outsiders. There will be an inside language, a sort of shorthand which the disciplines use internally; but then they must also learn to speak to those outside in a more general and less technical language.

Only as both theologians and scientists develop an adequate proficiency in such two-language structures can we hope to have communication and genuine interaction within the community. This does not mean that outsiders must be denied access to the technical language; technical language should not be used by any group to prevent communication with the outside; the function of language is not to obstruct communication but to facilitate it.

There must be frequent passage between the two languages, both in theology and in the scientific disciplines. (SSS 76–82)

